

Commission for Higher Education and Research—as regulators.

The most disturbing critique came from the Dr Yashpal Committee, set up to study reforms in the higher education sector. “Universities grow in organic connection with their social, cultural and geographical surroundings and even the best of them can’t be transplanted somewhere else and expected to do as well,” says Dr Yashpal, an eminent educationist. “Don’t we want the best learning experiences to be shared by our students? If so, can this not be done by opening our doors to foreign scholars?” he asks. The Planning Commission also came forward, supporting this view and called for laying out of the purpose of the bill.

Neither Harvard nor Columbia University or other top-ranking institutions would come to India, says Madras University Vice-Chancellor G. Thiruvassagam. “Even the universities which come here would not offer a need-based curriculum. That’s why even within the country and state we are opposed to a common curriculum under which the local needs are not addressed,” he says, adding that in Coimbatore, for instance, a university could offer a course in textiles or in Tirunelveli one could teach courses on fisheries. “This need-based approach would be missing in foreign universities.”

The biggest challenge for the Government is to attract top-ranking universities to the country. Most premier universities, except a few, have resisted the temptation to grow globally, choosing instead to enhance quality by maintaining low student-teacher ratios and focusing on excellence in research. Wharton’s decision to create a small campus in Silicon Valley, the recent setting up of campuses in Dubai and Singapore are the only notable excep-



“Once the Bill is passed, foreign educational institutions will be able to set up their campuses here and then it will be very difficult to rein them in.”

MURLI MANOHAR JOSHI, BJP LEADER

TRICK OR TREAT?

FOR FOREIGN UNIVERSITIES

- Foreign universities will help meet the target of increasing the number of students going for higher education from the present 12 per cent to 30 per cent
- The arrival of such universities will bring global educational standards to the country. Intellectual potential in academia can be put to better use.
- Indian students spend \$13 billion every year on foreign education and the move would curtail the flow of money abroad

AGAINST FOREIGN UNIVERSITIES

- Universities like Harvard are scaling back their expansion plans and may not be ready for investments
- Clauses that stop repatriating profits will dampen major foreign investments
- India may end up attracting lower-quality providers who are keen on making money rather than improving learning
- Foreign universities will create a new class system and may weaken the public university system

UNIVERSITIES COMING TO INDIA

University of Houston, US Planning dual degree programmes with Benares Hindu University

Georgia Institute of Technology, US Plans to set up a campus in Visakhapatnam

Schulich School of Business, Toronto, Canada Intends to set up a campus in Hyderabad with the GMR Group

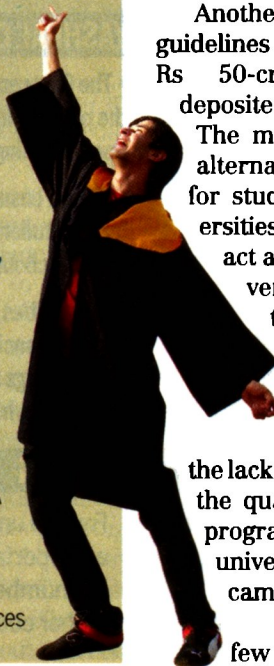
Deakin University, Australia Exploring M.Tech collaboration

Southern Illinois-Carbondale, US Exploring partnership in engineering and computer science programmes

Tufts University, US Seeking partners for the executive exchange programme

Roosevelt University, US Looking for collaboration for MA in training and development

University of Rochester, US On a hunt for associates for courses in liberal arts and sciences



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tion. “Universities like Southern Illinois-Carbondale, South Dakota and Case Western Reserve are looking for research collaborations with India in areas like nano-technology, aerospace, genetic engineering, terrorism, psychology and IT,” says S.B. Anumolu, president, Indus Foundation.

Another hot button issue in the guidelines is the condition that a Rs 50-crore corpus fund be deposited by the aspiring institute. The money will be used to find alternative educational facilities for students, if any foreign universities cease operations. This may act as a deterrent for many universities to come to the country. Many are also fretting about the decision to keep foreign universities out of applicability of reservations and the lack of a mechanism to compare the quality of the education and programmes offered by a foreign university in India with its main campus abroad.

Predictability is a trait that few would ascribe to educational reforms in the country. The deemed universities, brought in with lot of fanfare, is the latest in the list of failures. The Government should ensure that foreign universities do not make the list any longer.

with inputs from Nandini Vaish